

Brick by brick, Krishan Pathak becomes the new Wall in Blue

Krishan Bahadur Pathak, a junior Hockey World Cup winner with over six years of national team experience, is poised **to take over the reins** from legendary goalkeeper P.R. Sreejesh.

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A familiar face was missing from the Indian men's hockey team's training session as coach Craig Fulton put his squad through their paces at the Sports Authority of India's (SAI) National Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru.

After serving as India's goalkeeper for over two decades, P.R. Sreejesh retired following his second consecutive Olympic bronze medal at the Paris Olympics.

The absence of his commanding voice, often heard directing defenders, was palpable as the sound of hockey sticks slicing through the turf and clashing echoed around the training complex. Stepping into the shoes of a legend like Sreejesh is a daunting task. His legacy extends far beyond his impressive 336 caps and exceptional on-field prowess. As a revered senior leader, he has left an indelible mark on the team. Now, Krishan Bahadur Pathak faces the challenge of filling this void.

Pathak, a 26-year-old from Kapurthala, Punjab, was born to parents who migrated from Nepal in search of a better life. He credits his success to the support of his family and their adopted state.

"We didn't have much money in Nepal. It was very difficult to manage, so my parents, with my three sibling, moved to Punjab, where I was born," Pathak reminisced during a

conversation with *Sportstar*.

"Punjab played a big role in shaping who I am today. If I had stayed in Nepal, my story would have been different. From what I've seen — all the struggles my parents went through, the jobs they took, and the small things they provided for me — it's all very motivating," he shared. Pathak's journey with hockey began when he joined his friends to play at the Rail Coach Factory (RCF) in Kapurthala.

"The coach at RCF told me that they didn't have a goalkeeper, and that's where my journey as a keeper started. After that, I was selected for the Surjeet Hockey Academy in Punjab," he said.

Succession plan

The men's hockey team has navigated the



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